

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH *of Los Angeles*

The Gospel of Life ~ The Gospel According to Justice Sonia Sotomayor October 19, 2025



*The Corner of 6th & Commonwealth
11 September 2018*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org
Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on FINLANDIA

Romance (Palero)

Conditor Alme (Gracia Baptista)

Solace (Scott Joplin)

Three Jazz Chorale Preludes (Johannes Michel)

- Erhalt uns Herr (*Swing Five*)

- Wunderbarer König (*Bossa Nova*)

- In dir ist Freude (*Afro-Cuban*)

Danse rituelle du feu (Manuel de Falla)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Brittany & Lance Skiles

These days, when slippery words and shaded truths are commonplace,
we gather to proclaim the honest good news of God's love for all persons.

These days, when internal stresses and global divisions abound and take their toll,
we gather to share a faith that is the source of healing and serenity.

These days, when demands for justice and commitment and compassion are great,
we gather to strengthen ourselves and one another for the tasks of being a people whose love is greater than our fear.

We give thanks to God for gathering us together as this community of faith.
*This day we shall work to change ourselves and our world,
as we share and strengthen our resolve to follow in the way of Jesus the Christ.*

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

From Wisdom Emerging

ST. DENIO

From Wisdom emerging, we fashion a space
for people converging in safety and grace,
to shelter the freedom of one and of all
in Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail
with others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"
Rejecting worn paths that oppress and mislead,
we walk in community, cherished and freed!

Forever exploring, we seek to learn more
of Wisdom's outpouring, of Love's open door.
Amazed at the mysteries and graces we find,
we joyfully share them with all humankind.

The future progressing, we move through its change,
old systems redressing, new patterns arrange;
protecting all the freedoms with every new choice,
we follow the Spirit and raise our clear voice!

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Eternal God,
we have gathered on this beautiful morning
to celebrate the life that is within us,
and around us.

Help us in these moments to realize once again
the incredible power that surrounds us –
power for new life,
power for healing,
power for possibilities.

Help us, O God, to look to one another
as we gather,
that we may on this day
know the truth of your great love
and the potential,
of what we can be
as children of the living God.

In this time,
may our singing be filled with transformation,
may our words reflect the yearning of our hearts,
and may the Spirit that builds within us as we gather,
hallow each and every passing moment
we know, in this place.

In expectation of what shall be,
we ask all of this
in the name of the One
we celebrate.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Una Velita"

BAD BUNNY

Lorenzo Zapata, Soloist, Dr. Christoph Bull and Dr. Ianthe Marini, Brandon Harris, Rhythm Section

*How did this moment come? The year flies by but this month always drags on. It's serious and threatening,
the sky is darkening, the wind is already blowing, the sea is getting furious, and the mountain is praying.
It's starting to rain, it's gonna happen again, here comes the storm, who will save us?*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Brittany Skiles

*Eternal Spirit, Earth Maker, Pain-Bearer, Life-Giver,
Source of all that is and that shall be,
Father and Mother of us all,
Loving God, in whom is heaven:
The hallowing of your name echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed by the peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done by all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom sustain our hope and come on earth.
With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure, spare us.
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.
For you reign in the glory of the power that is love, now and forever.
Amen.*

[pmoore/newzealandprayerbook]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

God created a wide diversity and beauty within humanity,
but we wonder sometimes how God feels about the great divides that we have created.

We do come today with the taste of ego-centeredness on our spiritual breath.
But we also come begging God to help us have a greater awareness and a deeper commitment
to finding that which will heal our world.

As a community of faith we seek to make good decisions about our daily living
so that who we are and what we do
can have a positive effect on our siblings everywhere
on this vast planet we all call home.

As you seek to live to follow the way of love, together...
May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Hebrew Bible

Isaiah 58:3-7

Lance Skiles

Thus says our God:
Is not this the fast that I choose;
To loose the bonds of injustice,
To undo the throngs of the yoke,
To let the oppressed go free,
And to break every yoke?
Share your bread with the hungry,
Shelter those without homes,
Clothe the one you see to be naked,
And turn not from your own kin.

Then will your light shine like the dawn...
If you do away with
The yoke,
The clenched fist,
The wicked word,
If you give your bread to the hungry,
And relief to the oppressed,
Your light will rise in the deepest night,
And your shadows will become like noon.

This is the witness of the ancestors.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Spirit of God,
You are the life-giving Spirit who sets us free.
You are both promise and uncertainty,
poverty and hope, comfort and challenge.

Inspire us with courage to proclaim the truth
and strength to work for justice and peace.

Waken in us a spirit of joy
that we may celebrate all that is good and human,
and all that is good and divine.

To the people whose names we know,
and to all those whose names are unknown,
and to each person here,
send your Spirit, O God,
to make us whole,
to make us know that you have created us in your image,
and that you are our Mother and Father,

our sibling, our friend,
our Ever-present God.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Temporal"

DR. DIANA V. SÁEZ & SUZZETTE ORTIZ

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*
Rev. Michael Lehman, Steve Gregoropoulos, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Rhythm Section*

*"There comes the storm! What will become of Puerto Rico when the storm arrives?
The people arise to the rhythm of the drums. The wind cannot bring us down,
nor ten thousand earthquakes. We are resilient. We are warriors."*

Sermon

The Gospel According to Justice Sonia Sotomayor

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Lance Skiles

*In our giving,
may our hearts be opened,
our hands unclenched,
our ears unclogged,
and our eyes opened
that we may feel and touch and taste and see
the breath and goodness of God in our midst.*

We invite you now to share your gifts for the work of justice in this place.

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Each week in our time together,
we are offered an invitation into the mystical.

Consider this: every spiritual system has an
understanding of healing the Earth.

Some express it very organically, through kinship,
others envision it philosophically, through stewardship.

But however it is articulated:
all of our faiths point us toward healing our planet.
I believe that tells us something.

We are all being pointed in the same direction.
Peace and unity are possible.
Healing is possible.
We can find them in our shared love of the Earth.
As a global family, we have a common Mother.

[Fr. Steve Charleston]

Offertory

"En mi viejo San Juan"
Anna Caplan, Molly Pease, Ianthe Marini, Trio

NOEL ESTRADA, arr. JOSÉ LUIS BLASCO

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Brittany Skiles

Holy One,
in a few moments we will leave this sacred time.
As we do, may we embrace the challenges of our lives and our world.

Help us to leave here with the certainty that you, O God,
love us and travel with us, wherever we may go.
Help us to relax into your love,
as we learn to live in openness to your Spirit
moving within us.
Help us to live as your people:
As your eyes, your heart, and your hands -
each and every moment of all our days.

*Give to us, Holy One, your joy and goodness
as we become sowers of your mercy,
nurturers of your hope,
and gardeners of your harmony -
both this day, and in all the days to come.*

Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

As we leave this sacred time
may we remember the good news
we have heard in this place.

May we find the peace that surpasses all understanding,
the peace of renewed purpose,
of a blessed unrest,
of realizing that the stories of our faith
are about our future - as well as the past,
and that there is work to be done:

*Proclaiming God's love,
healing the brokenhearted,
speaking out for the oppressed,
and above all,
opening to your call
that asks us to live
as those who dare to hope.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"We Would Be One"

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

JEAN SIBELIUS

TEXT BY SAM WRIGHT

*Hymn for the Journey

We Would Be One

FINLANDIA

We would be one as now we join in singing
Our hymn of love, to pledge ourselves anew
To that high cause of greater understanding
Of who we are, and what in us is true.
We would be one in living for each other
To show to all a new community.
We would be one in living for each other
To show to all a new community.

We would be one in building for tomorrow
A nobler world than we have known today.
We would be one in searching for that meaning
Which bends our hearts and points us on our way.
As one, we pledge ourselves to greater service,
With love and justice, strive to make us free.
As one, we pledge ourselves to greater service,
With love and justice, strive to make us free.

-Lyrics by Sam Wright

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Danse rituelle du feu - Reprise (Manuel de Falla)

Inside The Music

"Justice Sonia Sotomayor speaks often of the influence of her Puerto Rican heritage, and that when she hears the poem *En mi Viejo San Juan*, set to music by the poet Noel Estrada, she feels an immediate visceral connection to the people, the place, and the pride that formed her. She has also spoken of her philosophy that dance is a way of life, and that on occasion, she plays salsa music to get all nine justices dancing together in the halls of the Supreme Court.

In our music of the day, we honor these philosophies and vibrant ways of life. In meditation, we sing the music of Puerto Rican composers Dr. Diana V. Sáez and Suzzette Ortiz whose piece, *Temporal*, speaks of the resilience of the people who resist, fight, and rise above together—a text illustrated

through the joy of the Afro-Puerto Rican *plena* rhythm of the region. We are reminded that *meditation* is also active and tangible, and sometimes best done through communal dance. In offertory, we feature female voices by honoring the song that connects Sotomayor to herself.

Through the introit music of BAD BUNNY, we celebrate the rich contributions from the people of Puerto Rico as a vital part of American culture, and we affirm that this culture and this language will never be erased! Like *Temporal, Una Velita* was a song of resilience written in response to Hurricane Maria: its title, translating to *little candle*, represents the power of the people coming together as a single flame. In close, we sing the Wright text, *We Would be One*, reflecting the conviction of Justice Sotomayor in this fervent prayer: *with love and justice—strive to make us free.*” -Dr. Ianthe Marini